The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope

The day of the Lord comes like a thief for the world, but believers are children of the light — and the hope of His coming is a purifying hope.

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Where this study fits

1 Thessalonians · ten studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5
An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church

02 1:6–10
The Many Faces of the Gospel

03 2:1–12
Delivering the Gospel

04 2:13–20
A Successful Life of Service

05 3:1–13
Facing Tribulation

06 4:1–12
A Life That Pleases God

07 4:13–18
The Rapture of the Church

08 5:1–11
The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope

09 5:12–22
The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations

10 5:23–28
'Til We Meet Again

"Finally" (4:1) marks the hinge: chapters 1–3 lay the foundation; chapters 4–5 turn that theology into life.

The Rapture and the Day of the Lord

Introduction · Two separate events

A

The Rapture

The church taken out — no signs need occur first

4:13–18

B

The treaty

The Antichrist's seven-year treaty with Israel

Dan 9:27 · "Peace and safety!"

C

The midpoint

The mask comes off — sudden destruction

about 3½ years in

D

Second Coming

Christ returns to the earth to deliver His people

end of the seven years

E

The Millennium

His thousand-year reign

the blessing

The Day of the Lord

- Judgment — seven years
- Blessing — one thousand years

"A thief in the night" · 5:2

- Describes the Day of the Lord
- Not the Rapture

Seven features of the coming Day

1 Thessalonians 5:2–3 · Introduction — and a key to the chapter

A **Secret**

“Like a thief in the night”

B **Unexpected**

While they cry “Peace and safety!”

C **Sudden**

Striking without warning

D **Destructive**

Catastrophic judgment

E **Inevitable**

Nothing can prevent it

F **Irreversible**

As labor pains — ὠδίν

G **Inescapable**

“They shall not escape”

✓ **Pronoun key**

You / we = believers · they / them = unbelievers

Sons of the day, sons of the night

1 Thessalonians 5:1–8 · I — Some differences

They / them — of the night		You / we — of the day **υἱός** sons of light · G5207
• Follow Satan’s deception: “Peace and safety!” • Asleep — spiritually unaware • Drunk — aware, but unable to respond • Sudden destruction; they shall not escape	vs	• Follow Scripture — they know “perfectly” • Not in darkness: the Day won’t overtake them • Watch — γρηγορέω; be sober — νήφω

The “sleep” of 5:6 is not the sleep of 4:13. There, physical death — a comfort word. Here, spiritual lethargy — a warning word.

The armor of the day

1 Thessalonians 5:8 · I.B.2 — The Lord's people

Breastplate of faith
θώραξ breastplate · G2382

Inward protection
- Keeps us obedient
- Keeps us trusting

… and of love
θώραξ breastplate · G2382

Outward protection
- Keeps us from shunning others
- Keeps us from neglecting others

Helmet: hope of salvation
περικεφαλαία helmet · G4030

Protects the mind
- Temptation always starts in the mind
- Guards against despair, doubt, distraction

Martin Luther: "I cannot keep birds from flying over my head, but I can keep them from making a nest in my hair."

Not appointed to wrath

1 Thessalonians 5:9–11 · II — Some deductions

A

Not to wrath

The Tribulation's wrath — not eternal condemnation

ὀργή · v.9a

B

To salvation

Through our Lord Jesus Christ — by the Rapture

v.9b

C

Wake or sleep

Alive or dead at His coming — we live together with Him

v.10

D

Therefore comfort

Comfort and build up one another

παρακαλέω · οἰκοδομέω

This is a purifying prophecy. The imminent return of Christ makes us want to work for Him today — to watch instead of sleep, to stay sober instead of drunk on this world's distractions, and to comfort one another. We are the Thessalonians.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 5:1–11 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. The sermon distinguishes the Rapture from the Day of the Lord. What is the difference, and why does it matter for reading this passage?

2. What is the difference between the “sleep” in 4:13 and the “sleep” in 5:6?

Apply

Put On the Armor and Keep It On
Each morning, name what you’re trusting God for, one person you’ll love that day, and the hope of your salvation.

Rest in Your Appointment
Memorize 5:9: “For God did not appoint us to wrath, but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ.”

In one line: Not appointed to wrath but to salvation — so watch, stay sober, wear the armor, and comfort one another.